

Basic Seitan dough

This is the basic dough recipe that will lead you to all other seitan dishes. It is an indistinct “meat” that needs a flavoring, marinade, or sauce to make it stand out. If you haven’t made **wheat meat** before, keep in mind it is simply one of those hands-on learning experiences best appreciated with practice. For example, depending on the humidity in the air and moisture content of your flour, the amount of water needed to create the basic dough may vary slightly from time to time. Extra water will create a softer meat; more flour, a firmer one. You will very quickly begin tweaking the recipes to your own liking, adjusting the texture and adding other flavors like minced garlic, onion powder, or soy sauce along with the water.

2 cups vital or high-gluten flour [250g]

2 teaspoons unrefined cane sugar

2 tablespoons nutritional yeast

2 teaspoons salt

1 tablespoon toasted wheat germ

1½ cups water [400ml]

1. In a large bowl, **combine** the flour, nutritional yeast, wheat germ, sugar, and salt. Toss to mix.
2. Add the water and knead the dough with your hands until the liquid is completely absorbed and the dough is firm and springy, about 5 minutes. Continue to **knead** for 2 to 3 minutes longer to get the dough tight and the flavors firmly incorporated.
3. If you plan on making one of the two roast seitan recipes, proceed to Savory Seitan Roast, page 236, or Free-Range Roasted Seitan, page 240. If not, **divide** the seitan into 3 equal oblong loaves. Lay down 3 pieces of cheesecloth, 8 to 10 inches [20 to 25cm] long. At this point, there are three ways to wrap the seitan:
 - Place a loaf in the middle of a piece of cheesecloth and fold the cloth over on all four sides to secure your package, not unlike a gift-wrapped present. Tie the

string around the package firmly but allow some give, as the “meat” will expand as it cooks.

- If you are using cheesecloth and no string, roll the seitan up in the cloth and bring the two ends together in a light knot.
- Finally, you can skip the cheesecloth altogether and just plunk the uncooked seitan in the boiling braising liquid as is. The advantage is a little less hassle. The disadvantage is that you will end up with odd-shaped pieces without a consistent shape, nor will they be quite as firm as if they were wrapped. Experiment, if you like, by wrapping two pieces of seitan dough and dropping the third in unwrapped. See which you like better.

4. Prepare either the Light or the Dark Meat Seitan, depending on which your selected recipe calls for. **Cook** the seitan in the liquid as instructed.

MAKES ABOUT 1 1/2 POUNDS [750G] (4 SERVINGS)

note You will need cheesecloth and white kitchen string for this recipe if you plan on boiling. (Alternatively, if you don't have string or don't want to bother, you can tie the ends of the cheesecloth together, like a bundle of laundry.) If you are making either of the roast recipes, you will *not* need cloth or string.